



Digital Exile: How I Got Banned for Life from AirBnB



Jackson Cunningham

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310K



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A few months ago, I received a cryptic message from AirBnB that sounded like something straight out that Black Mirror episode with Jon Hamm.

Dear Jackson,

*We regret to inform you that we'll be unable to support your account moving forward, and have exercised our discretion under our Terms of Service to disable your account(s). **This decision is irreversible** and will affect any duplicated or future accounts.*

*Please understand that **we are not obligated to provide an explanation** for the action taken against your account. Furthermore, we are not liable to you in any way with respect to disabling or canceling your account. Airbnb reserves the right to make the final determination with respect to such matters, and **this decision will not be reversed.***



blocked

At first, I wasn't concerned. Surely there must be a misunderstanding. After all, I've been a loyal AirBnB evangelist from the early days - using it frequently for business travel in the early days of tuft + paw (my high end cat furniture store, PSA: we're hiring!). I referred dozens of friends when it first launched. I even convinced my parents to list their vacation properties.

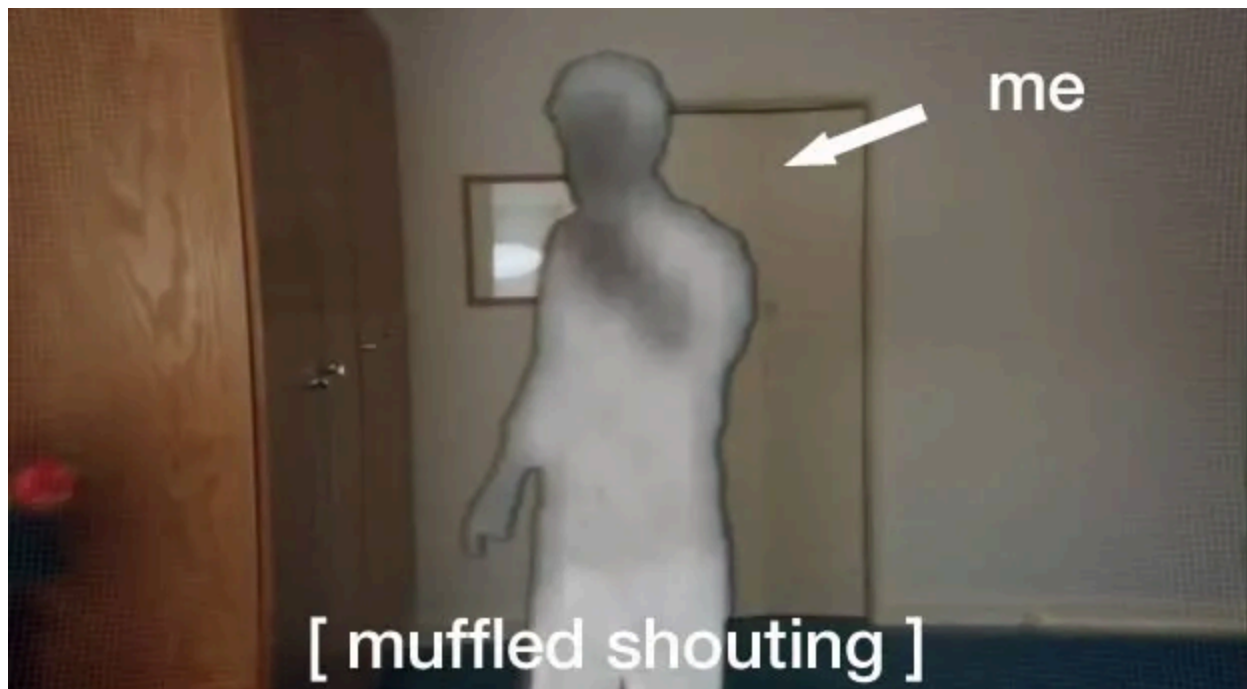
After reaching out to support, I received the following unsettling email.

Hi Jackson,

Please understand that *we are not obligated to provide an explanation* for the action taken against your account. Additionally, *we consider this matter closed and will no longer reply to any inquiries regarding your account.*

Okay, this is a tough spot. Somehow I've violated the terms of service, but they won't tell me which ones. And I can't communicate with them anymore.

Seems a little harsh.



At this point, I was pretty shocked but also very curious about what I could have possibly done. After carefully reading the AirBnB terms of service and reading about the most common ways people get banned from AirBnB, I went through each of my bookings. My first thought was that I must have inadvertently paid one of the hosts in cash because this is the #1 reason why people get banned. But I confirmed that all my bookings were paid through AirBnB. No foul play there.

After discussing with my girlfriend, the only thing we could think of was that we had recently had a very uncomfortable AirBnB experience with a rude host.

Here's a brief summary of the incident that likely got me banned.

After booking the weekend, we were told that we'd need to vacate the premises from 12–4pm because the room was located in a spa retreat.

The conflict arose when the host entered the room an hour early, unannounced. She forgot to let us know she'd be coming an hour early with spa guests. We weren't dressed but she continued setting up while we eventually scurried outside in front of the spa guests.

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When the trip was over, we decided not to leave a review after giving her the benefit of the doubt that it was just a bad day. The property itself was great.

A few weeks later, I saw that the host left me a critical review with completely distorted details from what had actually happened



Jackson and his girlfriend were great guests to host however we had a stressful situation arise and I found them both to be very reactive and not willing to accept our 60 min mistake in check out time. We accept two night booking during the summer months only with an agreed upon vacate time (11am-5pm DAY SPA which is usually booked prior to airbnb bookings and requires use of the main room unless they booked treatments) We had several moths earlier agreed on 12pm and it was our error in showing up at the usual 11 am. Instead of moving breakfast to the garden gazebo Jackson continued to argue his point and it was stressful and difficult for me to get the task at hand completed. I was extremely apologetic and expressed "time s of the essence here" and hoped we could discuss the details later. I felt they both acted quite entitled and were very non understanding. We offered them both complimentary spa products and a catered eggs benny breakfast the following morning and we had no response or thanks for even offering to help rectify the situation. A late check out of 2pm was scheduled months prior but they left by 11 am on the Sunday. I hope they enjoyed their stay and we did our best. Mistakes occasionally happen and communication and willingness to accept is essential in working it out. I wish we would have had some reply regarding our gifts to try to make this error up to them.

I emailed AirBnB to report that the host had fabricated details in her review — details which could be proven within the AirBnB platform. But I was told it's against their policy to censor reviews, even if they're dishonest.

Because the review period had passed on AirBnB and I felt the need to do some justice to my side of the story, I left a review on Google instead. The host has received a number of similar complaints so it definitely wasn't an isolated incident.



Jackson Cunningham - [Edit](#)

9 months ago on Google

1/5

There were several communication issues - we weren't aware you need to vacate the space from 11-5pm which makes you feel like you need to sneak around, never fully unpacking.

Host needs to work on communication with her guests because she comes across as quite rude. The accommodation was enjoyable but our stay was quite awkward because we were actively trying to avoid her.

Our real issue was the way we were spoken down to. It really made us feel like we were second class because we were *just* hotel customers without booking spa treatments.



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Response from the owner 9 months ago

Jackson obviously didn't read our airbnb listing and we are very clear on how our retreats are mainly a one night basis and more of a spa retreat with services rather than just a place to stay. He tried to not leave the spa building when I had other guests arriving at 11:30am so I merely set a firm request that he enjoy his breakfast outside in the garden as we needed time to get in and clean for our day guests arriving. He didn't like that. We tried compensating him but he wouldn't accept our grace.



Reviewed November 9, 2016

Rude Host, Terrible Customer Service, Low Quality

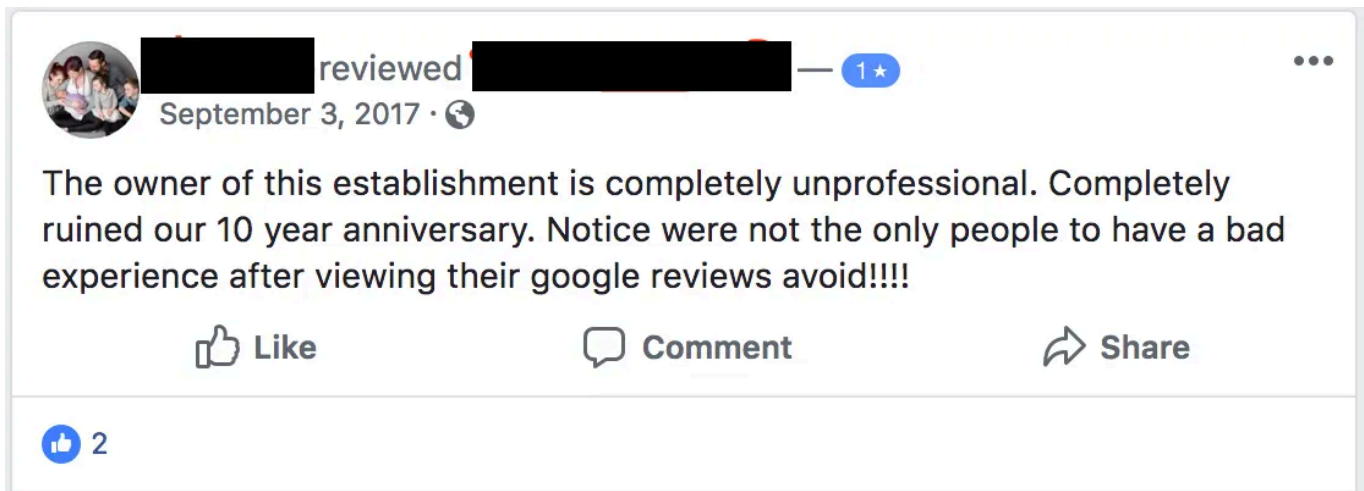
As has already been mentioned in previous reviews, the host [REDACTED] is absolutely horrendous. She is rude, has no customer service skills, and is unfortunately quite incompetent. The other people there are actually lovely, but the experience I had with [REDACTED] following my originally good experience (minus the amenities, which are really subpar for the price) when I went to order products from [REDACTED] online (mind you - very overpriced products) completely soured any positive thoughts I had about [REDACTED] 100% skip it for the price, rudeness of [REDACTED] and the shabby amenities.

[Show less](#)

Ask [REDACTED] about [REDACTED]

10 Thank [REDACTED]

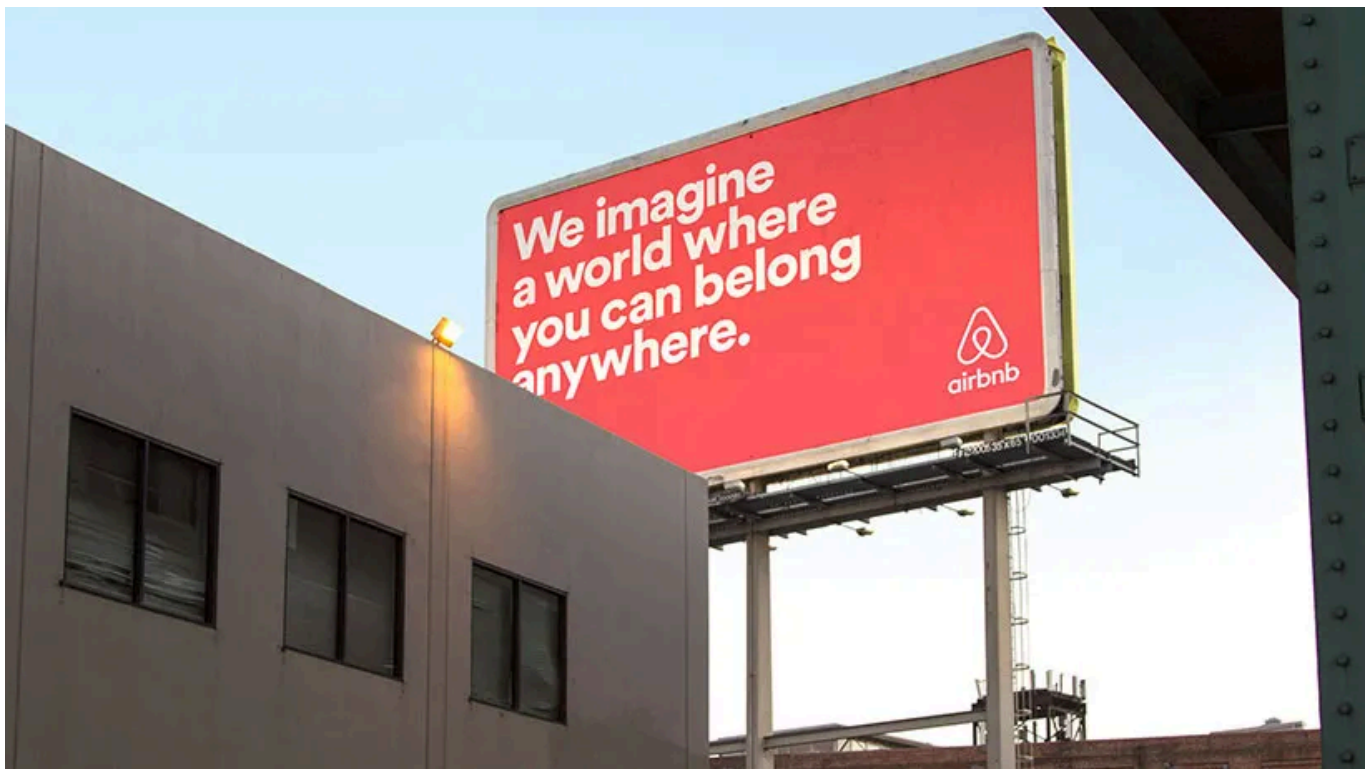
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I still can't believe that leaving an offsite review was a bannable offense, but even more disturbing to me is the way AirBnB handled the situation with a one-sided, permanent, irreversible, closed book suspension.

The part that's especially poetic to me is that AirBnB touts a firm brand message of community and connectedness with their "Belong Anywhere" campaigns but the frightening reality is that any individual user is completely disposable, without a shred of appeal to due process. I'm really thankful that I wasn't reliant on AirBnB income like so many of my friends.

But let's call it like it is. This policy leverages the company's power over the individual user to a cruel and unprecedented extent. And it's in laughable contradiction to the brand's inflated idealism.



After emailing AirBnB support and its founders multiple times, I've finally given up.

Moving forward, I question whether these types of suspensions should be allowed from the tech giants without any oversight or regulation. At what point does a company become pervasive enough in everyday life that they owe users an explanation or warning before dropping the guillotine? Or is this all part of an ongoing trend, toward something like the Chinese Social Credit Score system, where the consequences of not maintaining a high rating are socially crippling?

We're becoming increasingly dependent on a handful of major tech giants to get through our basic daily routine. Imagine waking up one day and no longer being able to check your Gmail, buy things on Amazon, or book an Uber.

It all feels very 1984. Or Black Mirror. The one with Jon Hamm.

Co-authored by Jackson and Jeff Cunningham.

You can find me on Twitter or by visiting my cat furniture store (PSA: WE'RE HIRING). It would mean a lot.



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Written by Jackson Cunningham

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Responses (1659)



Write a response